

It is not easy to define the Black community. It is a culture, African-Americans specifically, that is largely new, compared to the centuries of history other races and ethnicities possess. It is ever-changing and morphing, and thus it is hard to find the words to accurately describe them and their behaviors. However, that is not to say the action is impossible but rather complicated and nuanced. As I discussed in previous papers, framing behavior in the Black community requires tracing back and understanding the history behind behaviors and mindsets. Being a queer Black person, it is in my interest to explore the history of white supremacy and its tools of oppression, and how they have survived and transformed into rhetoric and reasoning seen in Black people today. More specifically, how Christianity, a tool of white supremacy, has caused Black people to reject queer Black people and how the Black community has yet to fully divorce itself from that.

Defining Blackness and Being 'Queer'

The Black Community is tricky with its membership. The question of what makes a person Black is not new, but rather the option for Black people to decide what constitutes someone as Black (Nittle). With the abolishment of slavery, Jim Crow was created in the south and introduced a slew of terms that described mixed-race Black people. Davis in his article discussing the concept of mixed-race points out that terms were made by White people who wanted African ancestry to be 'traceable' and to prevent 'passing' something racial mixing could cause and most white people feared. As a result, the Black identity was not decided by actual Black people. The one-drop rule coupled with racial terminology essentially eliminated any other forms of ancestry and defined Black for us as it is rooted in white supremacy. With that being

said, for decades being Black lied solely in a person having Black ancestry and how the law categorized them.

As time went on and Jim Crow faded away and race became more phenotypic for Black people. In an article discussing now Vice President Kamala Harris, Nittle talks about the history of the Black identity, stating “...mixed-race people were typically encouraged to identify — or simply identified in society — as Black, even if they looked racially ambiguous...” (Nittle). Many mixed-race people were not vindicated until the census in the 2000s allowed people to identify as multiracial (Nittle). While race may still be very phenotypical in the U.S, race as a concept is becoming less and less binary. So the question still becomes, how do Black people define who *is* Black?

The answer to that question is still even more complex and divided. In the age of the Black celebrity, there have been many people who have been called into question about whether they are Black. Celebrities like Kehlani have largely been accepted as Black, but upon further inspection, they are mixed race, something she has said herself (Nittle). People often debate whether or not people like her are Black or should be classified as mixed, and there’s no universal answer or solution. It’s evident with differing opinions on people like Jhene Aiko. She is less than half-Black but has people defending her Blackness in spite of that (Person). To some members of the Black community, being multiracial or biracial does not deny you from being Black, so there’s no clear consensus on the answer. In my opinion, being Black depends on your heritage and also how you both look and are socialized. You must at least have a Black parent and visibly look Black. Race is phenotypical in the US, and as a result, people are socialized and treated based on how they look. In an article by Powell, “The Problem of Othering” he talks about racism as a form of othering. He states, “ Individual acts of discrimination on the basis of

group-based stereotypes harms its victims, but group-based categories and meanings are social and collective.” Racism is a group-based category of othering, and as such, it shapes the community as a whole and informs their behaviors and thoughts. Being Black in America is full of struggles, and those are integral to the Black identity. To visibly be able to pass for another race, it absolves you of anti-Blackness and the racism we so often experience. If you don’t experience those things, then you cannot be Black. However, my opinion is one of many in a larger conversation that’s only beginning to shape. So, the easiest way to then define membership in the Black community is by having a Black parent at minimum. An easily traceable form of Blackness and one that, at the very least, makes you half-Black or biracial.

Being Black is complicated, but thankfully being ‘queer’ is less so. The easy way to identify someone as queer is by how they identify themselves. Queer is a word defined as strange, but in an American social context, it’s come to mean someone a part of the LGBT+ community. It is best said by Cheves in her article “What Does ‘Queer’ Mean?” that goes in-depth on the meaning of queer when she says this, “First, there is “queer” as an umbrella term. Rather than use the alphabet soup of LGBTQIIAAPSS+, “queer” encompasses any non-cisgender, non-heterosexual identity, relationship, behavior, or desire.” Queer people are gay, lesbian, trans, and many other identities as indicated by the plus tacked on to the end of the community name. It’s a melting pot of many different identities or just people who have been othered through their non-cisgender or heterosexual identities, and queer is just the umbrella term for it. Being queer and Black is just an intersection of those many identities and being Black.

The Stems of Anti-Queerness in the Black Community

Being Black or queer in America is already stifling, being both is even more so. The intersection of identities is like existing at the margins of society largely against you. Think of being queer and Black as two identities coupled together to form something new. Each identity presents its own host of problems when presented to the opposite group. There exists racism in the queer/LGBT+ community and phobias against queer people in the Black community, so to say being both is difficult would be an understatement. I am more concerned with the anti-queerness that exists in the Black community and how it leads Black people to neglect their own, especially in a world where all we have most of the time is each other.

A story that I consider to be a keystone of my life, and ironically one of my earliest memories, was a game during first grade. During the game, the boys were to chase the girls and tag them. The dichotomy of gender is something that piqued the interest of my younger self as much as it frustrated me. It was not until I was much older that I understood why this was, but still, I complied. I remember voicing my discontent with being on the boys' team, I wanted to be one of the girls. My request was denied by my teacher and I remember the teasing my peers made towards me at that moment. They said things like 'ew' or called me 'fruity,' a term that was like an insult to men gay at the time. Embarrassed, I went silent and the game started shortly thereafter. I remember complying for some part of it, but during the other I started to just run nowhere, hoping that a boy would chase me like he did the girls. I'll never forget the moment I turned around from running aimlessly to an empty field as the other kids played somewhere far away. I remember telling my mother this sometime later that day. I broke down crying and said, "I want to be a girl," in my frustration. I remember clearly my mom getting angry with me and spanking me for my outburst and yelling, "Boys can't be girls Aj."

It's a childish story, I'll admit. However, it's one of those memories I often reflect on and think "What would have happened if my mother was accepting of me?" It's a question that's echoed through my life and one I don't think I'll ever be free from, but I think it's something I've managed to come to peace with through all the fighting. The rhetoric being one of heteronormativity and rigid gender roles, that often manifests itself in forms of homophobia, transphobia, etc. This sort of vitriol and rhetoric was not isolated to me and my mother, but one shared and taught by Black parents to their children since they've been able to. It's one that shapes the rejections of queer Black people and the isolation they face at the hands of their own community.

The anti-queer sentiments expressed that day, and often throughout my life can be traced back to white supremacy, more specifically the Bible. During slavery, white people used the Bible and Christianity to justify what they were doing. Something in an article I read by Zauzmer resonated with me. In it, he talks about the origins of pro-slavery theology in Christianity that was used to oppress slaves. He states, "So much of early American Christian identity is predicated on a proslavery theology. From the naming of the slave ships, to who sponsored some of these journeys including some churches, to the fact that so much of early American religious rhetoric is deeply intertwined . . . with slaveholding: It is proslavery." The church had roots in supporting slavery and using theology to help advance their own goals. Pro-slavery clergy used the Bible to advance their own rhetoric. From arguing their enslavement was understandable due to Africans being descendants of Ham, or arguing that they should obey their 'earthly master' to promote docile behavior. This conditioning that was used on slaves slowly trickled into their mindsets and beliefs. Most early slavers were adopters of African spirituality, but it slowly turned into a majority of African-Americans believing in Christianity.

Eventually, abolitionists and those who advocated against slavery came to reject using the Bible as justification as slavery. A quote by Fredrick Douglass is one I reference a lot when thinking about how Christianity was integrated into the Black community. He says, “I, therefore, hate the corrupt, slave-holding, women-whipping, cradle-plundering, partial and hypocritical Christianity of this land. Indeed, I can see no reason but the most deceitful one for calling the religion of this land Christianity...” Douglass’s beliefs echo a larger sentiment in the Black community. He is someone who has pushed against the idea of Christianity, but you’ll note that he does not condemn the religion, but idealizes the impartial god. It’s a double-edged sword, the Bible was used to oppress Black people for centuries but then became their path to freedom. Zauzmer states that “The foremost objectors, of course, were African Americans themselves. Large numbers adopted the faith, and they quickly began remaking it into their own.” This reclamation of sorts is what lead to the development of the baptist denomination of Christian faith in the 18th century, and something widely worshipped by African-Americans, especially in the south (Maci).

Fast-forward to today, faith and religion are something many Black people hold dear. In an article by Masci, he states that roughly 79% of African-Americans are Christian. It’s clear to see that it’s had a hold on the Black people, unsurprising from the generational way it’s been conditioned on them and passed on. I remember early on, my mom would always dress me up for Church and make it one of those times where you had to behave without question. I was never told why we believed in God, and to question it would mean upsetting my parents and family. It was something most Black people accepted without question, integrating itself into our lives without pretense. It is also so present in our language. Our elders would often use phrases like ‘Lord’ or ‘Jesus’ in times of crisis or as remarks. Children weren’t allowed to use it as it was

using the 'Lord's name in vain' and was disrespectful. Early on, so many of us were taught to be respectful of this figure we really had no idea was, and that was just the way it was. It was the same for so much of my family too. My cousins and I would talk about how much we hated going to Church and how their parents made them go too, but it was something they took on themselves to continue, me being the outsider and choosing to no longer worship. It's also a principal form of 'fighting' racism to many Black people, as many people see faith and prayer as not only a tool to manifest better for themselves but fight the ongoing racism they face (Mohamed et al).

While God was integrating itself into our lives, so were his 'teachings.' Black people practically grow up in Church, it's essential to our identity almost. God is always thought to be generous if you worship and obey his teachings. I remember when it came out that I liked boys, my mother stated that "God created Adam & Eve, not Adam & Steve," implying that same-sex people were not meant to love each other. This sort of interpretation is how many people think of queer people, and it's not the only one. It's something that slowly alienated me from my family. I remember her always commenting on how I felt like the "Black sheep" of the family. It's something I never quite understood, nor was I able to articulate why it bothered me so much until I got much older. When I was younger, I was more in denial of my traumas, but now I realize them and can see how her words and actions brought me to a point, a distance, that she picked up on.

The Bible has passages that condemn forms of queerness, like homosexuality. The most famous one appears in Leviticus 18:22 where he says, "You shall not lie with a male as with a woman." It's one of the more outright lines from the Bible that condemn homophobia and, thus, colored the interpretation of sexualities of many queer people and has lead to homophobia in

Christian communities. People have had a long-standing history of using the Bible to justify their forms of anti-queerness and deciding whether or not it is sinful. The sentiment is also taught and passed down in many churches. A notable instance occurred two years ago when the Church of England said that, “sexual relationships outside heterosexual marriage are regarded as falling short of God’s purpose for human beings.” The statement doesn’t surprise me. I remember in my own church when talking about homosexual relationships, my pastor talked about how God made man and a woman. He talked about how men have ‘plugs’ and women have ‘sockets,” an innuendo for how their biological parts were made for each other. This sort of rhetoric is common in many Christian spaces, but especially baptist ones. It’s learned and encouraged, the hate and anti-queerness that inhabit Black people. It’s the same rhetoric that my own family has used on me when I ‘came out.’ With religion being so integral to Black people, they view homosexuality and transgenderism as a sin and thus immoral, often condemning the people completely. Heterosexuality being the norm has fostered heteronormativity in many Christian circles, but especially Black people.

Continuing off the point of heterosexuality, the Bible also hosts rigid gender roles. A line from Timothy 2:12 states, “I do not permit a woman to teach or to exercise authority over a man; rather, she is to remain quiet.” These sorts of lines continue to foster and create rigid gender roles in the Christian community. These are the normative frames Bruner brings up in his work on the frames that inform our behavior and actions. Women are often expected to submit and men to provide and exercise control. These rigid teachings also continue to foster heteronormativity and things like transphobia. People often see these roles are unquestionable, and to go against them is to go against God, to sin. They interpret these lines and scriptures as a guideline on how to act, and queer people often break the mold of that. In addition, god created the man and woman, and

his blessing their matrimony has led it to develop some moral significance, foreboding things like homosexuality, divorce and etc, and continued to dictate how people interpret things that do not fit that heteronormative frame (Religious Institute).

How Black Queer People Get Neglected

I say all this to illustrate the depths from which anti-queerness stems. Christianity was once a tool used to justify the enslavement Black people faced but then transformed into their primary form of faith. The religion itself however has heteronormative roots and condemns forms of queerness like homosexuality. Thinking about it critically, anti-queerness in the Black community is rooted in Christianity. It's an agent of white supremacy Black people have yet to divorce themselves. To me, Christianity is white supremacy, preserving in the Black community. However, one may argue, like McLuhan that it is not the religion itself that is bad, but rather who it is used by. I do wonder, however, is it possible for such a religion to be divorced from morals in the sense is it good or bad, given the negative history, it has. Regardless the religion has become a part of the Black community and so has its teachings, so then the question becomes, what happens to Black queer people?

I remember growing up never quite fitting with my family and being the 'Black sheep.' I recall my uncles often remarking about my behavior negatively and urging me to 'fix' it. Little microaggressions that occurred over the years led me to be too afraid to express myself in any capacity. Things like "stop talking with your hands" or "boys don't walk like that or talk like that." There was never a time where a facet of my identity did not feel attacked. I didn't fit in with the girls of my family either because they viewed it as weird for me to constantly talk or play with them, so there wasn't much middle ground when it came to exist. I was ousted, and that was really about the end of it. My mother was so often frustrated with me and my behaviors

that she felt too embarrassed to take me or even being associated with me. It manifested more violently when she tried to convert me at one point. I'll remember the day vividly. On the eve of my brother's birthday, they found texts where I talked about my interests in men. She threatened to kick me out and I wasn't allowed around my siblings for some time for fear of touching them inappropriately. I remember crying and feeling at my worst and wrote a text to my grandpa asking for help, that I wanted to kill myself. She found it the next day and encouraged me to, and even handed me the knife. I didn't go through with it, couldn't, and she got mad and threatened to do it herself. It was traumatic and something that's shaped my mental psyche and health. I don't think I've ever truly been happy since then, but I live with it. I am trying to get help these days, but it's just another one of those things I don't think I'll ever escape from. Overall, I experienced this universal neglect when it came to my family. I didn't conform to their normative frames of how a man should act, nor did my sexuality exist in accordance with the Bible.

This sort of neglect is something every queer Black person goes through, or most at the very least. We do not fit in with behavioral frames set upon us through religion and oftentimes experience vitriol and hate at the hands of the people we often need. The queer community isn't particularly 'progressive,' many queer Black people talk about the fetishization and outright racism they face at the hands of people they consider a part of their community (BBC). It leads Black people to feel that they are not a part or do not belong in the LGBT community. It's another alienation that pushes them further away from a real community. Not to mention, the world at large isn't too accepting when it comes to queer people, so there's really nowhere for them to go. It would be nice for the Black community to be a safe space for their fellow Black peers who are queer, but instead, they reject them, placing them even further in the margins of

society. It's lead to queer Black people creating spaces specific to them because there's not quite one place they fit in. In an effort to write about the Black queer identity, Tim interviews Black queer people in the UK. It's where I learned about Black Pride, a thing many queer Black people celebrate because of that alienation I spoke to earlier. It's hard to find your tribe among your identities when all of them seem to alienate you one way or the other (Jalloh).

In addition to alienation, it's killing us. Forestiere talks about the 'war' on black trans women that's been on the rise recently, stating, "Their deaths are part of a horrifying pattern; hate crimes against transgender and gender non-conforming individuals have been on the rise for years, with the number of murders in 2020 already almost surpassing that of 2019." Queer people are becoming more targeted because of their identities. Being Black presents its own hosts of racial violence, but coupled with other less accepted identities, it puts them in danger. I remember being on the verge of homelessness several times in my life because of my parents. The physical abuse I faced from my family and the lack of anyone who ever cared. Black Queer people are facing hateful violence both physically and emotionally so often, but no one ever really speaks up for us or cares. It parallels so closely to Black death in America, the rising number of Black people killed in racial violence, and justice is never received. Black people's experience so closely mirrors queer peoples, especially Black queer people. They have to stick up for us because no one else will, and alienating your own does nothing but further oppress us. Our problems go unseen and that's why trans women deaths are at a record high. It's something that resonates with me so strongly and scares me because that could be me. One day, revealing my identity could kill me, and in the end, no one would care.

Conclusion

Black people's anti-queerness is a direct result of white supremacy and how they've yet to divorce themselves from it. Generations of slavery and religion have intersected to form the Black baptist, but continuing to not question the roots of the religions and ideals itself has lead Black people to neglect their own. I write about this because the cycle is violent. Black queer people are Black too, and rejecting them doesn't do anyone any good. We are witnessing Black people using instilled rhetoric to suppress queer voices, imitating their oppressors in a world where all they really have is each other. I also think it's important because Black people do not realize how they are hurting and using the same methods of oppression used on us, on queer people that exist within our community. It's time that it changes because if they don't care for us, then who will?

Works Cited

- Bruner, J.. "Frames for thinking: Ways of making meaning." (1996).
- Cheves, Alexander. "What Does 'Queer' Mean? 9 LGBTQ+ People Explain How They Love, Hate, and Understand the Word." *Them.*, Them., 4 June 2019, www.them.us/story/what-does-queer-mean. Accessed 22 Apr. 2021.
- Davis, F. James. "Mixed Race America - Who Is Black? One Nation's Definition | Jefferson's Blood | FRONTLINE | PBS." *Pbs.org*, 2014, www.pbs.org/wgbh/pages/frontline/shows/jefferson/mixed/onedrop.html. Accessed 23 Apr. 2021.
- Fitzsimons, Tim. "What Does It Mean to Be Black and Queer in America Today?" *NBC News*, NBC News, 19 June 2020, www.nbcnews.com/feature/nbc-out/what-does-it-mean-be-Black-queer-america-today-n1231500. Accessed 22 Apr. 2021.
- Forestiére, Annamarie. "America's War on Black Trans Women | Harvard Civil Rights-Civil Liberties Law Review." *Harvardcrcl.org*, 2020, harvardcrcl.org/americas-war-on-black-trans-women/. Accessed 28 Apr. 2021.
- Holy Bible, New International Version. Zondervan Publishing House, 1984.
- "LGBT Racism: 'I Felt like a Piece of Meat.'" *BBC News*, 14 Feb. 2020, www.bbc.com/news/av/uk-51497280. Accessed 23 Apr. 2021.
- McLuhan, Marshall. *Understanding Media: the Extensions of Man*. Abacus, 1973.
- Masci, David. "5 Facts about the Religious Lives of African Americans." *Pew Research Center*, Pew Research Center, 7 Feb. 2018, www.pewresearch.org/fact-tank/2018/02/07/5-facts-about-the-religious-lives-of-african-a

mericans/. Accessed 22 Apr. 2021.

Mohamed, Besheer, et al. "Faith among Black Americans." *Pew Research Center's Religion & Public Life Project*, Pew Research Center's Religion & Public Life Project, 16 Feb. 2021, www.pewforum.org/2021/02/16/faith-among-Black-americans/. Accessed 23 Apr. 2021.

Nadra Nittle. "Kamala Harris Is Asian and Black. That Shouldn't Be Confusing in 2020 — but It Is to Some." *NBC News*, NBC News, 12 Aug. 2020, www.nbcnews.com/think/opinion/kamala-harris-asian-Black-shouldn-t-be-confusing-2020-it-ncna1236501. Accessed 22 Mar. 2021.

Powell, John A. "The Problem of Othering: Towards Inclusiveness and Belonging - Othering and Belonging." *Othering and Belonging*, 29 June 2017, otheringandbelonging.org/the-problem-of-othering/. Accessed 23 Apr. 2021.

Rae, Noel. "How Christian Slaveholders Used the Bible to Justify Slavery." *Time*, Time, 23 Feb. 2018, time.com/5171819/christianity-slavery-book-excerpt/. Accessed 22 Apr. 2021.

Transgenderism, Transsexuality, And Gender Identity | Religious Institute. "Transgenderism, Transsexuality, and Gender Identity | Religious Institute." *Religious Institute*, 2017, religiousinstitute.org/denom_statements/transgenderism-transsexuality-gender-identity/. Accessed 23 Apr. 2021.

Twiggy Jalloh. "5 Women Reflect on What It Means to Be Black and Queer in the UK | British Vogue." *British Vogue*, British Vogue, 13 July 2019, www.vogue.co.uk/article/what-is-it-like-to-be-Black-queer-woman. Accessed 23 Apr. 2021.

Zauzmer, Julie. "The Bible Was Used to Justify Slavery. Then Africans Made It Their Path to Freedom." *Washington Post*, The Washington Post, 30 Apr. 2019,

www.washingtonpost.com/local/the-Bible-was-used-to-justify-slavery-then-africans-made-it-their-path-to-freedom/2019/04/29/34699e8e-6512-11e9-82ba-fcfeff232e8f_story.html

. Accessed 22 Apr. 2021.